
Analysis of far-right discourse

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Abstract

1 This paper analyzes the evolution of far-right political discourse in France through
2 the study of electoral manifestos from legislative elections between 1978 and 1993.
3 Using a corpus of around 1,500 documents extracted from the Archelec database,
4 the study applies several Natural Language Processing methods, including La-
5 tent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), Non-negative Matrix Factorization (NMF), and
6 BERTopic. The results show a strong continuity of key themes such as immigration,
7 national preference, security, taxation, and opposition to the left. However, signifi-
8 cant changes appear over time. In particular, the period between 1988 and 1993
9 marks a shift from a more emotional and rhetorical discourse to a more structured
10 political program with concrete policy proposals.

11 Over the last decades, far-right discourse has changed a lot, both in its content and in its place within
12 the political space. Far from being marginal, it now plays a role in shaping public debates, especially
13 on issues such as immigration, identity, and security. Therefore, one key challenge is to understand
14 how this discourse emerged and how it has evolved over time. The analysis of electoral manifestos
15 from legislative elections allows us to observe these changes across time.

16 1 Literature Review

17 1.1 Understanding the structuring discourse of the far right

18 Mude proposes a now classic definition of far-right parties as based on the combination of three
19 elements: nativism, authoritarianism, and populism [5]. This combination helps to understand the
20 structure of these discourses, especially around the idea of a homogeneous “people” facing internal
21 or external threats, whether from elites or immigrant populations.

22 From a linguistic point of view, the analysis of Marine Le Pen’s speeches shows that immigration is
23 systematically constructed as a “crisis”. The study by Jamet and Lafiandra shows that the far right
24 uses a parallel between the migration crisis and the climate crisis in order to present immigration as a
25 massive and uncontrollable threat [2]. In addition, terms related to immigration are associated with
26 negative words, creating an implicit and reinforced evaluation of the migration phenomenon.

27 However, these discourses cannot be analyzed independently from their circulation in the political
28 space. A study by Houard-Vial highlights the role of local contexts in the reception and appropriation
29 of these discourses, showing an ambivalence between ideological proximity and strategic distance
30 within the traditional right [1].

31 While the literature shows a link between rhetorical and semantic mechanisms and contextualized
32 social and political dynamics, Natural Language Processing offers a particularly useful tool for
33 analyzing the first dimension. Thus, we aim to analyze the characteristics of far-right political
34 discourse.

35 Finally, although Mondon emphasizes the contemporary normalization of the far right, we choose
 36 to focus on legislative election manifestos between 1973 and 1993 in order to better understand the
 37 emergence and structuring of these discourses [4].

38 1.2 Natural Language Processing tools used

39 We use methods from Natural Language Processing (NLP), especially three complementary topic
 40 modeling methods:

- 41 • *Latent Dirichlet Allocation* (LDA), a classical probabilistic model;
- 42 • *Non-negative Matrix Factorization* (NMF), a more deterministic and often more interpretable
 43 algebraic method;
- 44 • *BERTopic*, a modern approach based on contextual embeddings (transformers), which
 45 captures semantic similarities that word-count methods cannot detect.

46 All these methods rely on principles of NLP, as presented by Daniel Jurafsky and James H. Martin [3].
 47 These authors explain that any computational representation of language is based on a simplification
 48 of text, whether using bag-of-words models or more complex vector representations. This reduction
 49 necessarily implies a loss of information, especially regarding pragmatic context and implicit
 50 meanings.

51 2 Data: presentation and construction of the dataset

52 The Archelec corpus collects digitized electoral manifestos from candidates in French legislative
 53 elections since 1958. These documents represent the official expression of each candidate’s electoral
 54 program.

55 The first step is therefore to extract only those from far-right candidates. A list of far-right parties is
 56 manually defined by combining available information for the period. It includes the Front National
 57 and its variants (Front National for French Unity, Front National Youth, Popular Front National), the
 58 Party of New Forces (main competitor of the FN on the far right in 1978 and 1981), as well as several
 59 smaller groups such as Ordre Nouveau or the Revolutionary Nationalist Movement.

60 The final dataset includes about 1,500 far-right manifestos. We observe a strong increase in the
 61 number of documents between 1978 and 1993, consistent with the electoral rise of the Front National
 62 during this period. The strong decrease between 1978 and 1981 seems historically consistent, linked
 63 to the fragmentation and weakening of the French far right at the end of the 1970s. However, we
 64 cannot exclude that some far-right manifestos are not correctly identified (independent candidates or
 65 party names that we may have missed).

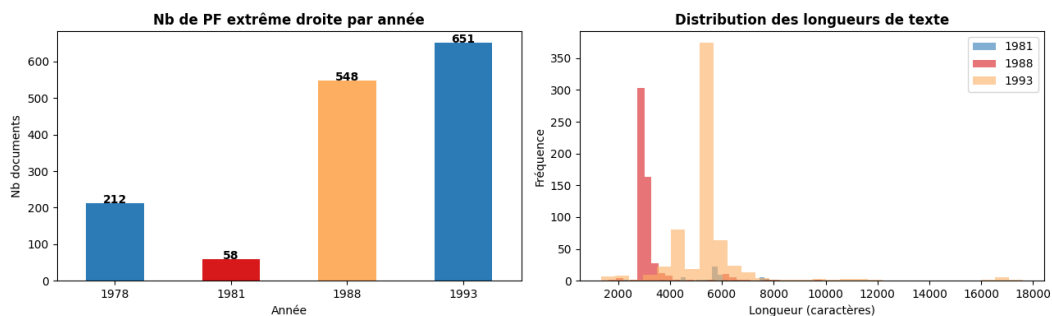


Figure 1: Number of far-right manifestos per year

2.1 Data processing

First, we lemmatize all texts using the **spaCy** library. Then, a list of stopwords is created by combining three sources: the default French stopwords list from spaCy, a list of general electoral terms (vote, suffrage, ballot, candidate, district, deputy, assembly, voter. . .) present in all manifestos regardless of political orientation, and an additional list loaded from a *.csv* file.

3 Latent Dirichlet Allocation

LDA is a probabilistic model. Its principle is to assume that each document is generated by a mixture of K latent topics, and that each topic is a probability distribution over words. The goal of the algorithm is to infer these distributions from observed data.

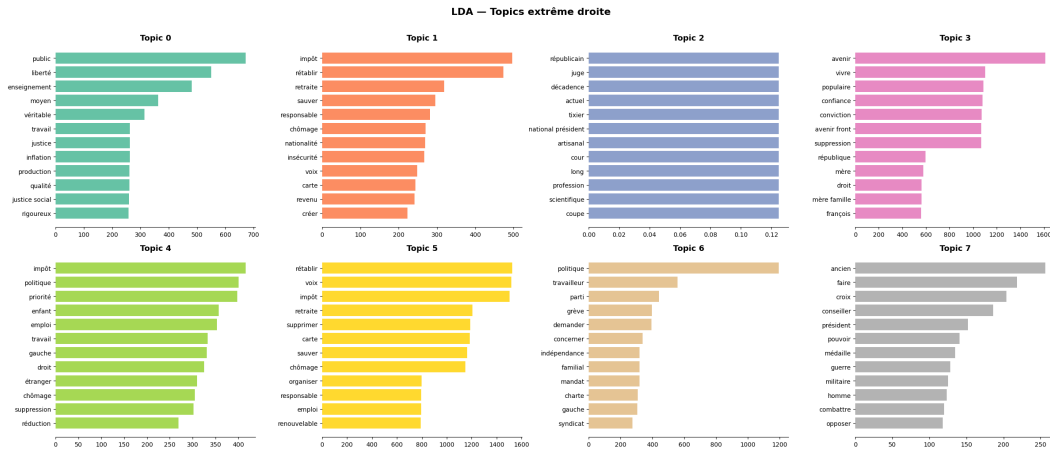


Figure 2: LDA topics

These results highlight some dimensions of far-right discourse over the period. Socio-economic concerns appear central, particularly around public services, work, and inflation (topic 0), as well as taxation, employment, and redistribution (topics 1 and 4). Issues related to nationality, insecurity, and welfare are also central (topics 1 and 5). Institutional and ideological critiques emerge in topic 2, with references to the judiciary, the Republic, and perceived national decline. A more affective register is visible in topic 3, with the future, popular appeal, and calls for support. Topic 6 reflects a political and social conflict dimension, structured around workers, strikes, and unions, while topic 7 mobilizes a more symbolic and historical repertoire linked to authority, the military, and national identity.

4 Non-negative Matrix Factorization

4.1 NMF on all years

Unlike LDA, NMF is a deterministic method that seeks to minimize the distance between V and its reconstruction $W \times H$, where documents are decomposed into a matrix V (documents $\times$ terms) equal to the product of two non-negative matrices (W and H).

We use *Term Frequency–Inverse Document Frequency* (TF-IDF), which weights each term by its frequency in the document divided by an increasing function of its frequency in the whole corpus. Thus, a term that appears very often in the corpus has a lower weight, while more distinctive terms are emphasized.

We identify several structured thematic registers in the corpus. First, a mobilizing and value-oriented register (topic 0) emphasizes political conviction, national recovery, and calls for support. Second, a set of topics captures concrete policy proposals, particularly on immigration and administrative control (topics 1, 3, and 4), including residence permits, border regulation, expulsion, and national preference. Third, an economic and social register (topics 2 and 5) focuses on production, inflation, social justice, labor organization, and fiscal redistribution. Finally, a more explicitly political and

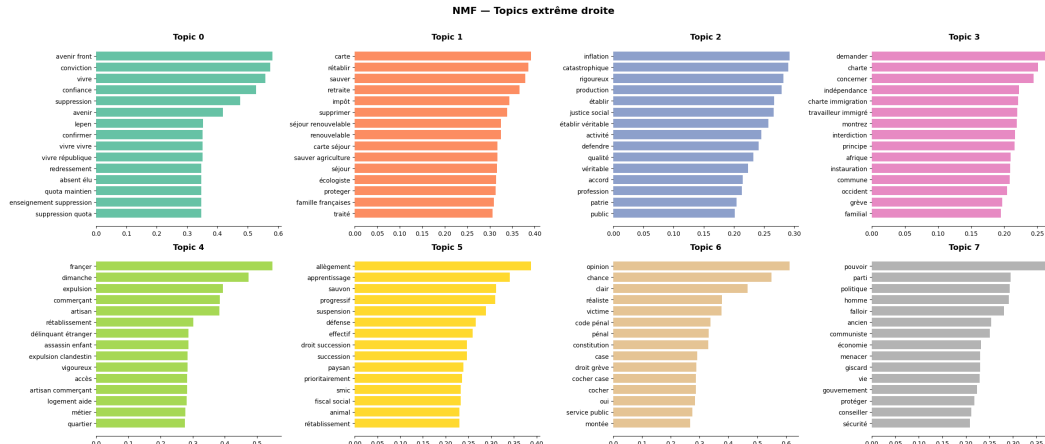


Figure 3: NMF topics

98 institutional register (topics 6 and 7) relates to law, public opinion, political actors, and ideological
 99 ideas.

100 The matrix W from NMF assigns each document a vector of weights for each of the 8 topics. By
 101 normalizing these weights and calculating their average by year, we obtain a measure of the average
 102 thematic composition of far-right discourse for each election.

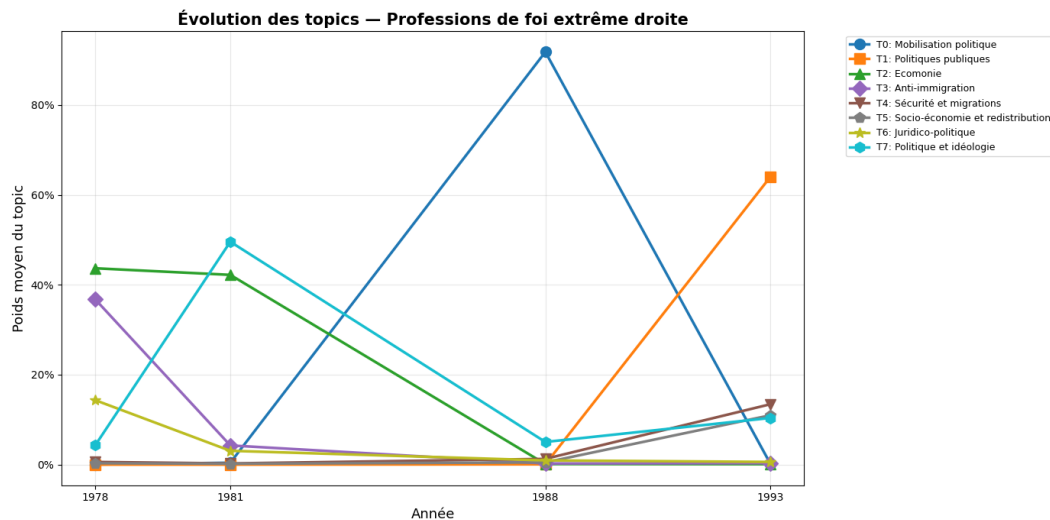


Figure 4: Topic variations over time (NMF)

103 In 1978, the corpus is structured around economic concerns and anti-immigration themes. Economic
 104 discourse and anti-immigration rhetoric dominate, complemented by a secondary juridico-political
 105 dimension. This configuration is consistent with the positioning of the Party of New Forces (PFN),
 106 which combines liberal economic priorities with a critical stance on immigration, without yet making
 107 it the exclusive core of its discourse.

108 In 1981, political and ideological positioning becomes predominant. The strong rise of the “politics
 109 and ideology” theme and the persistence of economic concerns reflects a moment recomposition. In
 110 the context of the Socialist Party’s accession to power, far-right actors want to be seen as a structured
 111 opposition, privileging identity and ideological conflict.

112 The year 1988 is a clear shift toward a mobilizing and value-oriented register. The dominance of the
 113 “political mobilization” theme illustrates a strategy centered on emotional appeal, conviction, and
 114 calls for support. This evolution follows the electoral increase of the Front National.

115 In 1993, the discourse becomes more programmatic and policy-oriented. The rise of “public policies”,
 116 combined with the reappearance of themes related to security and migration and socio-economic
 117 redistribution, shows a shift toward more concrete proposals. Immigration remains a structuring issue,
 118 but is now embedded in a broader and more articulated political platform, including administrative
 119 regulation, social policy, and institutional positioning.

120 5 BERTopic

121 BERTopic encodes each document as a vector of embeddings using a pre-trained language model.
 122 We use paraphrase-multilingual-MiniLM-L12-v2, a multilingual transformer model from the
 123 Sentence-BERT family, well suited for French texts.

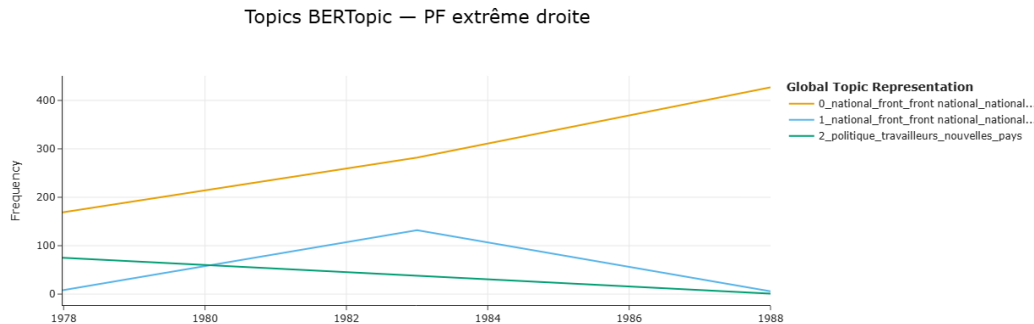


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124 BERTopic initially identifies around forty topics, which are subsequently reduced to for through
 125 automatic merging, allowing for a more interpretable thematic structure. Only a limited number of
 126 documents are classified as outliers, indicating a relatively good overall fit of the model to the corpus.

127 The first and most dominant topic appears in a large majority of documents. It is structured around
 128 national issues, immigration, and unemployment. It highlights the centrality of national preference
 129 and labor-related topics in far-right discourse across the period.

130 A second topic is less frequent but still significant. It reflects a register of political mobilization and
 131 partisan projection. It emphasizes the future and ideological conviction.

132 A third topic captures a more programmatic and political register, structured around workers, the
 133 party, and policy proposals.

134 6 Conclusion

135 This analysis reveals a strong structural continuity in far-right discourse between 1978 and 1993.
 136 Across all models, several thematic dimensions emerge: immigration and national preference, socio-
 137 economic concerns (employment, taxation, inflation), security, and ideological opposition to the left.
 138 These themes are already established in 1978, suggesting that the foundations of far-right discourse
 139 are rooted in earlier political configurations.

140 Also, the analysis highlights important transformations in the articulation of these themes. The early
 141 period is characterized by an equilibrium between economic concerns and anti-immigration rhetoric,
 142 but also a strong positioning against the left. In 1981, this oppositional dimension intensifies, reflecting
 143 a conjunctural moment and the need for far-right actors to change themselves in a reconfigured
 144 political field.

145 The most significant shift occurs in 1988, with the emergence of a discourse centered on political
 146 mobilization, values, and voter appeal. Rather than developing detailed policy proposals, the Front
 147 National prioritizes emotional resonance and the consolidation of its electoral base..

148 In 1993, the discourse evolves once again toward a more programmatic and institutionalized form.
149 While immigration remains a central structuring topic, there also are a broader set of public policy
150 proposals, including administrative regulation, socio-economic measures, and governance-related
151 themes. This shift reflects a process of political professionalization and normalization, as the Front
152 National increasingly presents itself not only as a protest movement but as a party capable of
153 governing.

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